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flection of laziness; it was an act of self-preservation,” says Singhal.

Mercer’s Global Talent Trends 2026 report captures the depth of this shift. Only 44% of employees globally report that they are thriving at work today, down from 66% in 2024, the least since this measure was introduced in 2018. In India, 74% of employees value working for a purpose-driven organisation, yet 54% are planning to leave for better pay.

“This is not a workforce that

has disengaged. It expects both purpose and fair reward, and will not compromise one for the other,” says Singhal.

She says ambition is being re-defined around greater alignment between personal values and organisational purpose, along with fair recognition. Improved financial literacy has also expanded the possibility of achieving financial freedom much earlier than previous generations.

That shift is changing the meaning of retirement. “The aspiration around early retirement warrants a closer examination,” says Singhal. “In most cases, professionals are not seeking an exit from work; they are seeking an exit from compulsion.”

Mercer’s data supports that argument. While 40% of employees globally plan to leave their organisation in the next 12 months, their motivations suggest they are not looking to abandon work altogether. In India, 45% cite greater control over where and when they work as a key retention factor, while 46% prioritise a positive workplace culture.

The trend is visible in the rise of freelancers, fractional CXOs, independent consultants and professionals building multiple careers simultaneously.

At the same time, burnout has emerged as a significant challenge. Mercer’s Global Talent Trends 2026 report says the loss of talent due to burnout or long-term sick leave is now cited as a top workforce concern by 44% of HR leaders, up from 16% in 2024. Singhal believes organisations must also recognise the difference between a job and a career.

Professionals who take time to reassess priorities, rebuild skills and realign careers are more likely to create sustainable and fulfill-

ing professional lives than those who default to resignation as the solution, Singhal says.

THE RETIREMENT MATH PROBLEM

While the emotional appeal of early retirement is easy to understand, the financial realities are far less forgiving.

Financial educator and author Monika Halan believes many Indians underestimate the sheer magnitude of the planning required. To make that possible, an individual would need to aggressively save and invest during the relatively short career window.

“In my view, unless you get lucky, it will not be possible in view of the funds required for independent living. Even five years of super-high inflation in retired years can leave you underfunded for years when you might see higher costs due to medical reasons.”

Rather than targeting a full retirement, Halan believes people should target financial independence. She also cautions against romanticising retirement. “People look at retirement as an unending party on the beach. What they forget is that a holiday has meaning only when there is work,” she says.

HOW MUCH IS ENOUGH?

If retirement at 40 is financially possible, what corpus does it actually require?

Mihir Vora, Chief Investment Officer at Trust Mutual Fund, argues that asking for a fixed number is misleading in a country as diverse as India.

“One number may not be applicable or comprehensible to all individuals in a diversified population of a large country like India,” he says. “A better way would be to look at a multiple of monthly recurring expenses.”